In January 1973, a fire destroyed the heritage iron and steel building of the Calcutta main office. A survey of the premises after the conflagration revealed that only two objects had escaped being burnt: a portrait of Mahatma Gandhi and a marble bust of Sorabji. N.M. Mistry recalls that since most of the records were destroyed in the fire, the bank declared that any person signing a special form and bringing his passbook with it would be paid ₹1,000 immediately. It was believed that this would attract thousands of customers but only 300 came, an indication of the faith in the bank.[13]

But above all, Sorabji's concern was for Indian banking to develop on the right lines so that the country could have a sound banking organization of its own. Thus, what occupied his mind after the years of initial struggle was not a narrow concern for the survival and prosperity of his own bank, but the banking system as a whole.

IDEAS

Sorabji was not just the founder of a bank; he also had his views on various aspects of the banking system. He did not hesitate to air these views fearlessly and candidly from time to time. His ideas, restricted in the beginning to experiments on behalf of the Central Bank, gradually took on a broader character, defining, as he saw it the guidelines by which Indian banks could set their course. 'In speeches and notes and articles he indefatigably propagated his views and sparked off ideas that bear witness to the fertility of his mind, the relevance of which is now confirmed.'[14]

Sorabji was all for expansion of banking in rural areas. He bemoaned the fact that despite all the high-sounding rhetoric about rural reconstruction, more attention had not been paid to inculcate the banking habit in the rural populace through constant and strenuous endeavour, as it was this section who formed the backbone of India's economic structure. Sorabji was categorical that salvation lay in setting up branches in rural areas with the object of infusing the saving habit in agriculturalists. Long before financial inclusion[15] became a valued objective, he strongly advocated the need for banks 'to turn their attention towards the interior, to penetrate into the country-side, to mobilize the savings of the rural folk and to cater to the diverse financial needs of the latter who, though standing in the greatest